

YOGEN KHATRI



ALLIED FORCES: Keshubhai (lighting the lamp) and other rebels with Congress leaders at a meet in Kutch

My Enemy's Enemy

With the poll process underway, the Narendra Modi-baiters in BJP and the Opposition Congress join hands in a last-ditch effort to oust the two-term incumbent chief minister

■ By Uday Mahurkar

They virtually ran the party once, presiding over important decisions. Today they are all set to leave BJP and join hands with the Congress to achieve their sole agenda: the decimation of Narendra Modi in the Gujarat Assembly polls slated for December 11 and 16. The anti-Modi lobby in BJP—comprising 11 MLAs and two sitting Lok Sabha members—led by former chief ministers Keshubhai Patel and Suresh Mehta and former Union textile minister Kashiram Rana, sounded the battle cry against Modi last week and went ahead with its joint strategy with the Congress. Apart from the heavyweight trio, the dissidents comprise MLA Gordhan Zhadaphiya, who was home minister during the 2002 Gujarat riots, MLAs Dhiru

Gajera and Jivraj Dharukawala, and MPs Vallabh Katheriya and Somabhai Patel.

Ever since the BJP high command closed all doors to the rebels last month, their nexus with the Congress has become stronger. Last week, Congress President Sonia Gandhi set up a committee, comprising party leaders Prithviraj Chauhan, Vayalar Ravi and B.K. Hariprasad, to consult the rebels and chalk out a common strategy to defeat Modi. The emphasis is on ensuring that the Congress vote doesn't split, while that of Modi does. Mehta, Katheriya and Zhadaphiya, who have held three meetings with Congress leaders so far, met senior Congressman Ahmed Patel in Delhi last week. The faction is reportedly demanding nearly three dozen Congress tickets, but the Congress is not in a

position to spare more than 10. It looks like all except Keshubhai, Mehta, Rana and Zhadaphiya will join the Congress, while these four will campaign against Modi from outside. Zhadaphiya says, "Our aim is to put together a strategy that will defeat Modi at any cost. Gujarat must be freed from his misrule." Says Mehta, "Under Modi, BJP is not going to get more than 65 seats."

The dissidents' chargesheet is long and weighty. They accuse Modi of being a fascist and running a dictatorship, using the state police apparatus to shadow senior leaders. Says Keshubhai, "Gujarat is facing a mini-emergency-like situation where individual freedom and democracy have lost all meaning." Their second charge is that though Modi talks about the interests of five crore Gujaratis, his Government is meant for his five